

Restoration Ethics Studio Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • The Arts • 30-40 min

Category	The Arts	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	restoration-ethics-studio

Big idea: Preserving an artwork can also alter what future viewers know through it.

Overview

Students decide how to restore a damaged artwork and analyze how restoration choices affect authenticity and knowledge.

Student Prompt

Inspect Restoration Ethics Studio Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Restoration Ethics Studio Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Scenario: a mural has faded paint, later graffiti, and a damaged corner. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Restoration Ethics Studio Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Options: clean only, repaint invisibly, preserve damage, add a modern label, commission a visible repair. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Restoration Ethics Studio Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Options: clean only, repaint invisibly, preserve damage, add a modern label, commission a visible repair. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Preserving an artwork can also alter what future viewers know through it.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Restoration Ethics Studio Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Restoration Ethics Studio Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Does restoration preserve knowledge or create new meaning?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how preserving an artwork can also alter what future viewers know through it.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Use a fictional artwork so students can focus on trade-offs rather than external facts.
- Give each group a different stakeholder priority.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Scenario: a mural has faded paint, later graffiti, and a damaged corner.
- Options: clean only, repaint invisibly, preserve damage, add a modern label, commission a visible repair.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Present a fictional damaged artwork and its background.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Groups inspect restoration options and stakeholder priorities.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Students choose a restoration plan and justify it with evidence and values.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Groups compare how each plan changes authenticity and viewer knowledge.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief whether preservation can be a form of interpretation.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Preservation is not neutral when every option changes what viewers encounter.
- What kind of authenticity are you prioritizing?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat interpretation as purely subjective and therefore beyond evidence.
- Students may ignore how context, form, and audience knowledge constrain readings.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Supports interpretation with formal features, context, and audience response.
- Explains why multiple readings are not automatically equal.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: use three restoration options.
- Challenge: include a budget constraint and public controversy.

Extension Tasks

- Students write a museum label explaining a restoration decision transparently.
- Compare restoration with editing a historical source or cleaning scientific data.

Related Activities

- Fake or Masterpiece?
- Curator Choice Gallery
- Context Collapse Gallery